

TMJ (TEMPOROMANDIBULAR JOINT) PAIN

TIPS & STRETCHES TO HELP YOU FEEL BETTER



TMJ pain can cause jaw pain, clicking, headaches, earaches, and difficulty chewing. Use these tips and stretches to reduce tension and support your recovery.



RELAX YOUR JAW

Keep your teeth slightly apart and tongue resting on the roof of your mouth. Avoid clenching or holding tension in your jaw.



EAT SOFT FOODS (SHORT TERM)

Choose softer foods and cut food into small pieces. Avoid gum, tough meats, and crunchy foods.



LIMIT JAW STRAIN

Avoid wide yawning, nail biting, chewing gum, or excessive talking. Support your jaw if yawning.



HEAT OVER THE JAW

Use a warm (not hot) compress over your jaw for 15–20 minutes to relax muscles. Heat is usually more helpful than ice for TMJ.



GOOD HEAD & NECK POSITION

Keep your head stacked over your shoulders. Avoid holding your head forward for long periods (phones, computers, driving).



SLEEP HABITS

Avoid sleeping on your stomach. Consider a supportive pillow and avoid pressure on your jaw.



BE PATIENT & CONSISTENT

TMJ pain often improves with time and consistent self-care. Small, daily steps can make a big difference.

WHEN TO SEEK CARE

Seek medical attention if you experience:

- Jaw locking (open or closed)
- Severe pain that does not improve
- Swelling in the face or jaw
- Numbness, weakness, or changes in sensation in your face
- Frequent or severe headaches
- Pain that interferes with daily activities



A clicking jaw without pain is common and usually not dangerous.

GENTLE EXERCISES FOR TMJ PAIN

1 RESISTED JAW OPENING



This helps improve jaw strength and control.

- Place your thumb or fist under your chin.
- Slowly open your mouth while gently resisting with your hand.
- Hold for 5 seconds.
- Relax and repeat.
- Repeat 8–10 times.

2 CHIN TUCKS



This helps improve posture and reduce strain on jaw and neck.

- Sit or stand tall, eyes forward.
- Gently pull your chin straight back, creating a “double chin.”
- Keep your head level—do not tilt up or down.
- Hold for 5 seconds.
- Relax and repeat.
- Repeat 8–10 times.

3 LATERAL JAW STRETCH



This helps reduce tightness in the jaw muscles.

- Place your fingers on your chin.
- Gently guide your lower jaw to one side.
- You should feel a gentle stretch on the opposite side.
- Hold for 20–30 seconds.
- Repeat on the other side.
- Repeat 2–3 times each side.

4 CONTROLLED JAW OPENING



This helps improve jaw mobility and control.

- Sit tall and relax your shoulders.
- Slowly open your mouth straight down.
- Stop when you feel a gentle stretch (do not force).
- Hold for 2–3 seconds.
- Slowly close.
- Repeat 8–10 times.



Listen to your body. These exercises should not cause sharp pain. Stop if you feel increased pain or discomfort and consult a healthcare provider.

IF YOUR SYMPTOMS PERSIST OR WORSEN, PLEASE FOLLOW UP WITH YOUR PROVIDER.

This handout is for educational purposes only and is not a substitute for professional medical advice. Always consult your healthcare provider with any questions or concerns.